

The Battle Cry of

With the Lok Sabha elections heading for a photo-finish, regional chieftains are likely to

By Ashok K. Damodaran

Making predictions, someone said, is a difficult task, especially when it is about the future. Trying to forecast the Lok Sabha elections, the largest electoral exercise in the world, involving 543 constituencies, seven national parties, 47 state parties and nearly 900 smaller parties registered with the Election Commission, not to speak of thousands of independents and 700 million voters—is an even more daunting task. INDIA TODAY has tracked election trends since the seventh General Election in 1980. The results of our latest survey suggest that the 15th General Election is set for the closest-ever finish; for the first time, instead of two, there will be three main contenders who each share about a third of the 543 seats.

In most elections, it is not until the final days that the race comes to life. This poll was conducted at a time of wild political fluctuations: the Biju Janata Dal in Orissa had unilaterally terminated its 10-year-old association with the NDA; in the UPA, senior partners formed a power bloc within the coalition while the PMK, a crucial ally in Tamil Nadu, walked across to the AIADMK camp which is part of the Third Front. The poll reflects the fluctuating fortunes of the three main groups brought about by these realignments. As a result, the ruling UPA is tipped to win 196-205 seats, far below the 234 it won five years ago, the BJP-led NDA just about holds on with between 172 and 181 seats, short of the 184 seats it got in 2004. The sole gainer is the motley group con-



REGIONAL BREAK-UP	NORTH		SOUTH		EAST		WEST		Total		Swing
	Total seats: 151		Total seats: 132		Total seats: 142		Total seats: 118		Total seats: 543		
	2004	2009	2004	2009	2004	2009	2004	2009	2004	2009	
	Won	Predicted	Won	Predicted	Won	Predicted	Won	Predicted	Won	Predicted	
BJP+											
Seats	49	44-53	24	14-23	36	34-43	75	68-77	184	172-181	-3.6%
Vote Share	30.6	35.9	24.7	13.4	34.4	24.2	46	47.5	33.5	29.9	
Cong+											
Seats	38	37-46	89	67-76	64	38-47	43	41-50	234	191-200	-3.5%
Vote Share	25.38	25.08	52.28	45.16	35.09	28.17	40.67	40.61	37.8	34.3	
Others+											
Seats	64	58-67	19	39-48	42	57-66	0	0-5	125	169-178	+7.1%
Vote Share	43.98	39.02	23.02	41.40	30.56	47.61	13.30	11.87	28.7	35.8	

(Vote share in per cent)